

WHO Academy annual report 2024



World Health
Organization

WHO Academy

WHO Academy

annual report 2024

WHO Academy: annual report 2024

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Cover page : A COVID-19 vaccination centre in Paz Flor mall in Luanda, Angola on 20 May 2021.
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Contents

Preface	iv
Introduction	1
2024: Year at a glance	3
Objective 1: Provide innovative learning content on WHO's and Member States' priorities	4
Delivering on the WHO Transformation Agenda	5
<i>WHO Academy Strategy 2024-2028</i>	5
WHO Academy flagships	9
Objective 2: Create high-quality learner-oriented courses	11
Online learning	12
Blended and in-person learning	13
Objective 3: Build a partnership-based global learning ecosystem that promotes innovative lifelong learning practices in the health sector	15
'A game-changer': WHO Academy opening	16
Convening global health and learning partners	17
Objective 4: Develop and disseminate quality standards and a competency-based recognition framework	19
Objective 5: Foster a culture of continuous learning within WHO	21
WHO Leadership Excellence Programme	23
WHO Academy governance and advisory groups	24
Annex 1: Online courses developed by the WHO Academy by priority area	25

Preface

In my second year as Executive Director of the World Health Organization (WHO) Academy, I am immensely proud to have overseen a significant milestone – the official opening of the WHO Academy campus in Lyon, France and the launch of the WHO Academy online learning platform.

In development since 2019, the Academy has continually evolved in both ambition and scope and has had to adapt its approach in response to new challenges, most significantly the COVID-19 pandemic and the disruptions to global health, and the global health workforce, that it set in motion.

But the end of the pandemic has not lessened the global health need around the world. The burden of noncommunicable diseases continues to increase, killing at least 43 million people in 2021, equivalent to 75% of non-pandemic-related deaths globally, with the greatest impact in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs). Meanwhile, communicable diseases still kill 7.5 million people every year.

The increasing number of global crises and the danger of future pandemics worsen these trends. Now more than ever, the global health workforce needs a continuous learning solution that can be accessed by all regardless of gender, ethnicity, social background or geography.

With the official opening and launch of the WHO Academy, that solution is now available to the world's 65 million health and care workers. New courses are being made available online for free, and through blended and in-person training, every month. These learning opportunities will support the health workforce to absorb new standards and scientific knowledge, integrate new technologies, and continue to learn throughout their career. Ultimately, the translation of these competencies into practice will contribute to saving lives.

None of this would have been possible without the commitment of the Government of France, the Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes Region, the City and Metropole of Lyon, and the private sector donor members of the *Soutien à l'Académie mondiale de la Santé Foundation*, hosted by the *Institut de France*. Our French partners have championed the Academy from the very beginning, and their ongoing support will ensure that we reach health and care workers across the globe, especially in LMICs.

On a personal note, I would like to thank WHO Director-General Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus for his unwavering trust in myself and the Academy team to deliver on this transformational initiative. I also must acknowledge the incredible efforts of my Academy colleagues, and WHO colleagues around the world, who pushed through many challenges and roadblocks to get us here today. The strength of WHO has always been its people, and it is a privilege to work with health and learning experts who are dedicated to making a safer and healthier world for all.

To quote a 2014 report from the Global Health Workforce Alliance, it is a universal truth that "there is no health without a workforce." The health workforce is the corner stone of health systems and will be critical to achieving health and wider development objectives in the decades ahead.



Dr David Atchoarena
Executive Director
WHO Academy



Introduction

The WHO Academy strives to enhance the lifelong learning capacity of the global health workforce and was established to respond to critical gaps in health worker education. The world is not currently on track to achieve the health-related Sustainable Development Goals by 2030, and progress is at half the required rate of change.

To make faster progress, health systems and health and care workers need to make better use of evidence-based solutions. Health and care workers also need better access to learning throughout their careers to adapt to evolving healthcare practices and to continually acquire the new skills needed to deliver programmes and services for essential public health functions. These needs are greatest in low-and middle-income countries (LMICs), and the Academy's priority is to reach learners in these countries.

According to WHO estimates, there were more than 70 million health workers in 2023 and there will be a shortfall of around 11.1 million by 2030, of which more than half will be in Africa. To accelerate the development of a skilled healthcare workforce, workers need access to efficient and evidence-based lifelong learning methods and greater ownership and engagement with their own learning.

Whilst WHO has been providing health guidance based on scientific evidence for the last 75 years, uptake remains too slow. At the same time, rapid scientific and technological advances have sped up the rate at which WHO issues new guidance. This has made it even more challenging for health and care workers and policy makers to keep pace and put WHO normative standards and guidelines into practice. There are many online health-related training courses available. However, the quality of these courses varies greatly. The lack of standardization of both course quality and operational recognition frameworks means that learners take risks taking courses that fail to improve their skills and competencies.

Within this context, the WHO Academy was opened and launched in 2024 with a bold vision - a world in which health and care workers, policy makers and the WHO workforce have the skills and competencies they need to achieve health for all – underpinned by five strategic objectives.



H. E. M. Emmanuel Macron
President of the French Republic
© WHO/V. Ramet

“Today we can be proud to open in the city of Lyon the doors of a new global institution, which will bring the best in terms of health training and innovation to the world. This investment will benefit us all, because better trained health workers are absolutely critical to make our world safer, including to prevent and respond to future pandemics.”

H. E. M. Emmanuel Macron
President of France
17 December 2024

Strategic objectives

1. Provide innovative learning content on WHO's and Member States' priorities.
2. Create high-quality, learner-oriented courses.
3. Build a global learning ecosystem that promotes innovative lifelong learning practices in the health sector.
4. Develop and disseminate quality standards and a competency-based recognition framework.
5. Foster a culture of continuous learning within WHO.



2024: Year at a glance

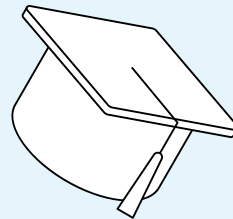
17 December 2024

Opening ceremony
of the WHO Academy in Lyon, France



49,000

No. of views of the
livestream of the
opening ceremony



7000+

No. of WHO
Academy learners

109

No. of WHO
courses available
on the learning
platform,
more than

7 times

the number of
courses on the
platform in 2023



192

Total no. of WHO courses
available on the learning
platform including
translations in

12 languages



30 No. of Member
States that are part of
the Group of Friends of
the WHO Academy



250

No. of WHO staff who participated in the first-
ever Leadership Excellence Seminar at the WHO Academy

Top countries

of registered users of
the WHO Academy learning platform:

1. India
2. Rwanda
3. Australia
4. Switzerland
5. United States of America
6. France



Objective 1:

Provide innovative learning content on WHO's and Member States' priorities

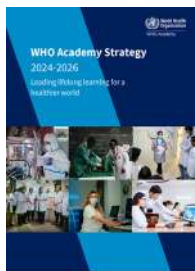


Delivering on the WHO Transformation Agenda

The official opening of the WHO Academy in December 2024 marked a significant milestone in the WHO Transformation Agenda, which was launched in July 2017. The most comprehensive change agenda in the Organization's history, this initiative aims to align all three levels of WHO to deliver on the ambitious strategic goals of improving the health and well-being of all people everywhere.

A central component of this transformation, the WHO Academy was initiated by the WHO Director-General to enhance the Organization's effectiveness in addressing the health training needs of its Member States. While capacity building has always been at the core of the WHO mission, the Academy supports countries to translate WHO normative standards and guidelines into the best health practices to improve global health.

By launching the Academy in 2024, and optimizing the Organization's expertise in capacity building, WHO is now better positioned to become a global leader in lifelong learning for health. Furthermore, the Academy will foster a culture of continuous learning and professional development of the WHO workforce, supporting staff in advancing their careers, enhancing their competencies and contributing more effectively to the Organization's goals.



WHO Academy Strategy 2024-2028

Ahead of the Academy's official opening, the *WHO Academy Strategy 2024-2026* was published in September 2024. This strategy charts a course to establish the WHO Academy as a global leader in lifelong learning for health. It presents the WHO Academy's vision, mission and strategic objectives to create a world in which health and care workers have the skills and competencies they need to achieve health for all.

The strategy recognizes that gaps in health education restrict the capabilities of the health and care workforce who are actively working in healthcare delivery to respond effectively to global health challenges. Limited access to high-quality and up-to-date information, coupled with varying educational standards and a lack of widely recognized competency frameworks, hampers the efficacy and responsiveness of the active global health workforce.

The WHO Academy theory of change (see figure 1) as defined in the strategy describes a pathway from the current state of global lifelong learning in health education to our vision: a future where health professionals, regardless of their location, can access world-class learning experiences. This change is predicated on strategic educational interventions, rigorous standards and a commitment to continuous improvement and collaboration.



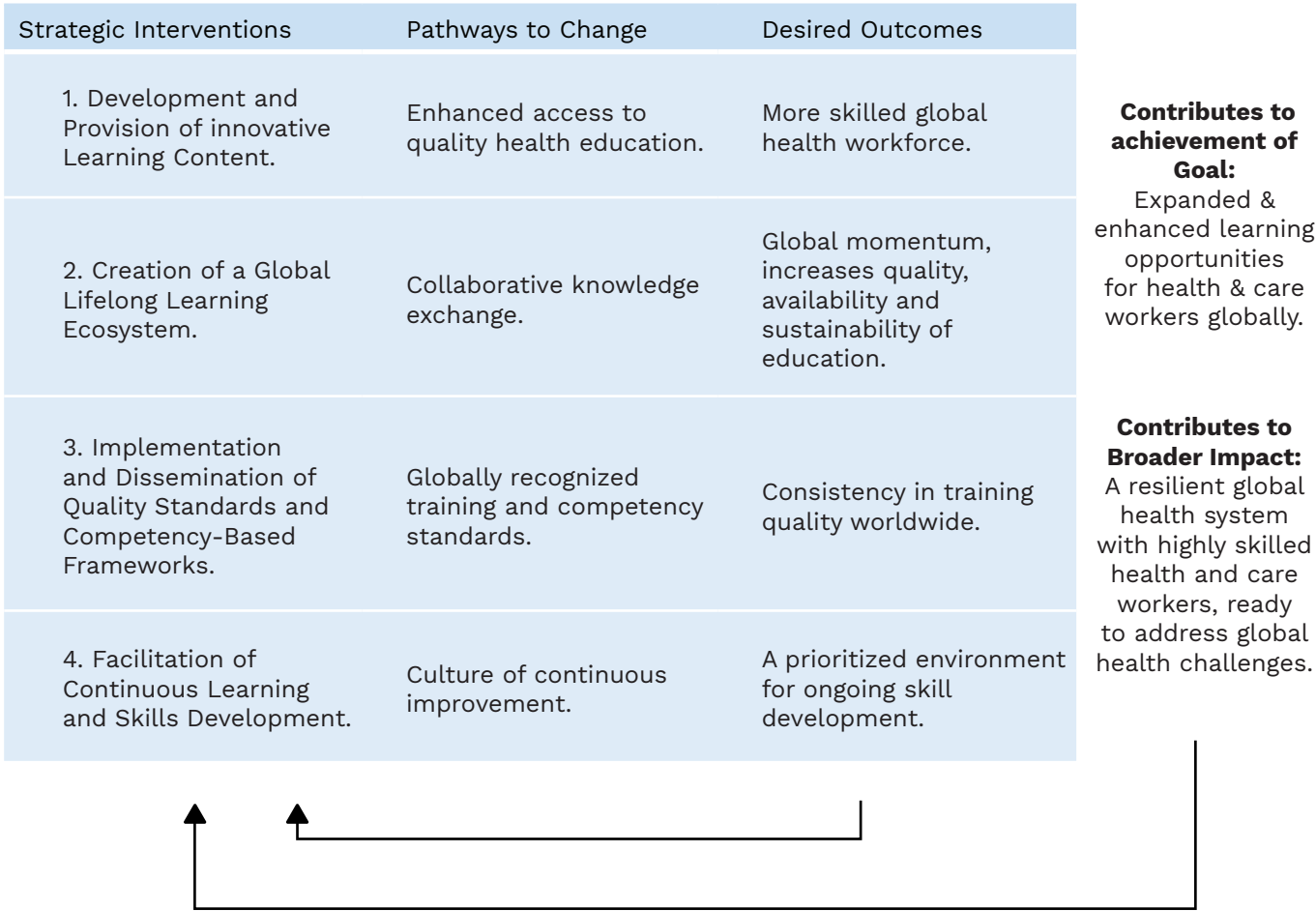
Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus
WHO Director-General
© WHO/V. Ramet

“In 2017, shortly after my election as Director-General, we set about transforming WHO into an organization that was more responsive to the needs of countries, and more effective in meeting those needs. The WHO Academy belongs to the final pillar of the Transformation – it aims to build the capacities of our own workforce, but also that of Member States. While WHO has had programmes to support capacity building before, it has never been institutionalized or implemented at scale. That is what the WHO Academy is about: delivering lifelong learning and capacity building at the scale that Member States and the WHO workforce need for health impact globally.”

Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus
WHO Director-General
25 November 2024

Figure 1

WHO Academy theory of change (see *WHO Academy Strategy 2024-2026*)



All learning that the WHO Academy provides responds to identified WHO priorities and is developed to meet current and future learning needs, including thematic priority areas and geographic location. In 2024, after a literature review of key WHO documents, and targeted consultations

with the WHO technical units and regional offices, learning solutions were identified and the final priority areas for course development (see figure 2) were reviewed and approved by the WHO Academy Internal Steering Committee.

Figure 2

WHO Academy priority areas for course development 2024-2025

Priority area	Definition with inclusion/exclusion criteria
Physical and mental health	
Behavioural and mental health	• Courses related to behavioural health topics such as eating disorders, gambling addiction, self-injury, and substance abuse • Courses related to mental health topics such as bipolar disorder, depression, schizophrenia
Infectious, neglected tropical, and non-communicable diseases	• Courses topics related to infectious diseases that are caused by pathogenic microorganisms such as bacteria, viruses, parasites, or fungi that can be spread from one person to another including HIV, TB, malaria; excludes sexually transmitted infections which fall under sexual health and reproductive rights • Courses topics related to neglected tropical diseases such as Chagas, dengue, and leprosy • Course topics related to non-communicable disease including: ◦ Chronic diseases such as cardiovascular disease, asthma and COPD ◦ Health promotion topics such as exercise, nutrition, alcohol and tobacco which aligns closely with urban health ◦ Cancer surveillance, prevention and early detection, control, and research infrastructures and methods
Sexual and reproductive health	• Courses topics related to reproductive systems including contraception, abortion, maternal health (pregnancy/antenatal health, childbirth, postpartum health), as well as sexually transmitted infections (excluding HIV, which falls under infectious diseases)
Health systems strengthening	Topics related to the six essential building blocks of a well-functioning health system
Health emergencies and emergency care	• Course topics related to strengthening global preparedness and response to health emergencies • Course topics related to strengthening management and delivery of emergency medicine
Health financing	• Course topics related to strengthening policies and management of health financing to promote financial risk protection
Health information systems	• Course topics related to health information systems, including the process of producing, analysing, visualizing, and using data to inform health system management
Health workforce	• Course topics related to the production, licensing, and management of the health workforce
Leadership and governance	• Course topics related to the processes, structures, and institutions that oversee and manage health systems at the country, regional, and global levels
Medical products, vaccines, and technologies	• Course topics related to the research, development, production, supply chain, and regulation of medicines and technologies, especially in LMICs
Primary health care (PHC) and universal health coverage (UHC)	• Course topics related to promoting PHC and UHC in regions and countries

Figure 2 (continued)

WHO Academy priority areas for course development 2024-2025

Priority area	Definition with inclusion/exclusion criteria
Transversal priorities	
Climate change	- Course topics related to climate-related hazards including extreme weather events, heat, sea level rise, air pollution, water scarcity, and reduced food production and their effect on climate-sensitive health outcomes including heat-related illness - Cross-cutting topic, aligns closely with health emergencies, One Health, and urban health
Digital health and AI	- Course topics related to digital health and AI, including policies, implementation, and use of digital health and AI products - Cross-cutting topic, aligns closely with health systems strengthening especially health information systems
Gender and human rights	- Course topics related to identifying, monitoring, and addressing gender and human rights issues - Cross-cutting topic across all thematic areas, aligns closely with health systems strengthening/primary health care, sexual and reproductive health, population-specific health, and urban health
One Health	- Courses related to One Health including AMR, laboratory capacity for diagnosis and surveillance, food and water safety, zoonoses, and field epidemiology - Cross-cutting topic, aligns closely with climate change, health emergencies, and urban health
Urban health	Cross-cutting topics that focus on improving health at the city-level, including social determinants of health such as the built environment (e.g., housing, transportation, sanitation and waste management), pollution, and heat. Also includes health literacy and education
Population-specific health	- Course topics related to specific WHO Academy priority populations, including: - Indigenous groups - Refugees and migrants - Newborns, children, and adolescents - Elders/healthy aging - Course topics related to maternal health covered under sexual and reproductive health and gender and human rights

WHO Academy flagships

The Academy has developed a comprehensive portfolio of programmes across most health topics addressed by WHO and tackles key priorities that require specific intervention. To ensure these priorities are addressed, the Academy has a focus on an evolving scope of priority programmes.

Beginning in 2024, three flagship programmes have been designed to support targeted WHO initiatives, namely: the WHO Biomanufacturing Workforce Training Initiative, the One Health initiative and the Healthy Cities programme and the WHO initiative on urban governance for health and well-being.

Biomanufacturing flagship

The African Union has set a goal for 60% of vaccines administered in Africa to be produced on the continent by 2040. However, there is an insufficient number of relevant vaccine manufacturing degree programmes, internships and apprenticeships in Africa to meet that goal. Programmes that do exist often focus on clinical training, so that graduates with relevant degrees are still not always equipped with the adequate biomanufacturing technical skills required.

In 2024, in support of this specific Member States' priority, the Academy leveraged existing WHO partnerships to create new, and strengthen, biomanufacturing learning pathways, especially in LMICs. The European Medicines Agency, with support from WHO headquarters and the Academy, planned a series of 'training of trainers' sessions for junior assessors from National Regulatory Authorities in Africa. As part of this collaboration, European Medicines Agency courses were identified for migration to the WHO Academy learning platform and new courses are being co-developed.

The Academy also contributed to the WHO Biomanufacturing Workforce Training Initiative, supported by the Republic of Korea, through the incorporation of quality assurance standards in the development, implementation and evaluation of training materials developed by the Biomanufacturing Global Training Hub. The hub invites trainees from LMICs for biomanufacturing training on-site in Seoul, Republic of Korea, and the updated training materials will be rolled out in 2025.

One Health flagship

One Health is an integrated, unifying approach to balance and optimize the health of people, animals and ecosystems. It uses the close, interdependent links among these fields to create new surveillance and disease control methods. The COVID-19 pandemic put a spotlight on the need for a global framework for improved surveillance and a more holistic, integrated system. Gaps in One Health knowledge, prevention and integrated approaches were seen as key drivers of the pandemic.

According to the World Bank, the expected benefit of One Health to the global community is estimated to be at least US\$ 37 billion per year. The estimated annual need for expenditure on prevention is less than 10% of these benefits. To implement One Health, major structural changes are required, including mapping of existing initiatives, capacities and learning needs to help build the next generation of the One Health workforce.



A health worker examines patient samples under a microscope at the Homa Bay County Teaching and Referral Hospital in western Kenya. ©WHO/Combrink

In 2024, as an integral part of WHO's work in the One Health Quadripartite and in collaboration with the World Organisation for Animal Health and the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, the Academy started the foundational work on a One Health learning strategy. The strategy focuses on mapping resources and identifying key priorities aligned with the Joint One Health Learning Initiative. The Academy also conducted a review of the One Health e-learning courses offered by members of the Quadripartite, contributing to the development of standardized training resources and best practices.

Healthy Cities flagship

Rapid urbanization is transforming societies worldwide. By 2050, nearly 70% of the global population is expected to live in cities, with much of this growth concentrated in LMICs. While unplanned urban expansion can pose health and environmental risks, cities are also uniquely positioned to drive health improvements. Cities are strategic actors that can mobilize stakeholders across sectors, implement integrated policies and engage communities to foster greater health and well-being. Cities can innovate and scale solutions promoting health in urban and local settings, making them key partners in achieving the Sustainable Development Goals and advancing health equity.

In September 2024, recognizing the importance of health promotion in urban settings, the WHO Academy and the WHO Western Pacific Regional Office co-organized a panel discussion, titled 'Learning for Healthier Cities', at the 10th Global Conference of the Alliance for Healthy Cities in Seoul, Republic of Korea. The panel highlighted how lifelong learning contributes to advancing the concept of healthy cities and how cities can become hubs for continuous learning

and improvement in public health, while the Academy also engaged stakeholders to explore partnerships aimed at strengthening urban health initiatives.

The Academy is working closely with the City of Lyon, a member of the WHO French Healthy Cities Network, as part of the Healthy Cities flagship programme. This collaboration supports the integration of the One Health approach into municipal public policies and aims to strengthen local governance in addressing interconnected human, animal and environmental health challenges through systems thinking and intersectoral coordination.

As part of its commitment to capacity building for healthy cities, the Academy is developing and integrating learning resources onto its online learning platform. A course, *Becoming a Healthy City*, developed by the WHO European Regional Office for the WHO European Healthy Cities Network, has been migrated to the WHO Academy learning platform, and an additional course is in development, in collaboration with WHO technical units, to help strengthen the capacities of local governments in addressing urban health challenges.



Objective 2:

Create high-quality learner-oriented courses



Online learning

In December 2024, the WHO Academy online learning platform was officially launched with a developing library of high-quality courses covering critical health topics, available on both desktop and via mobile app. The Academy focused on creating an inclusive platform that supports 25 languages and offers personalized learning experiences through artificial intelligence and machine learning, ensuring accessibility for diverse learners around the world. The platform's adherence to accessibility standards and multilingual support has broadened its reach, and at the end of 2024 there were close to 7000 registered users.

The pace of learning design and production increased significantly in 2024, with 97 WHO courses added to the WHO Academy learning platform. These included 19 entirely new courses designed and developed with WHO technical units (see figure 3 and annex 1), 74 courses (plus additional language versions) migrated across from the OpenWHO platform, and one course added from the WHO International Agency for Research on Cancer.

Courses were available in 12 different languages on the platform at the end of 2024.

Furthermore, strategic partnerships with the Pan American Health Organization and Training in Assistive Products has expanded the number of courses available to learners, with 71 gateway courses (in 15 different languages) made available in 2024. Gateway courses are produced and hosted on external e-learning platforms that can be accessed through the WHO Academy learning platform. This modality will gradually be introduced with a growing number of partners.



The WHO Academy online learning platform is available on both desktop and via mobile app.

Figure 3

No. of online courses developed by the WHO Academy by priority area

	Thematic priority	No. of courses
Physical and mental health	Behavioural and mental health	2
	Infectious, neglected tropical, and non-communicable diseases	2
	Sexual and reproductive health	7
	Health emergencies and emergency care	9
Health systems strengthening	Health financing	1
	Health information systems	5
	Leadership and governance	1
	Medical products, vaccines, and technologies	1
	Primary health care and universal health coverage	3
Transversal priorities	Climate change	1
	One Health	1
	Population-specific health	1
Total		34

Blended and in-person learning

In 2024, the Academy, in collaboration with WHO technical units, delivered eight blended and in-person training courses with participants from multiple countries in Africa and Europe. The delivery of these courses (see figure 4) demonstrates a comprehensive approach to enhancing learning experiences across various platforms and methodologies, including webinars, seminars,



Nurses receiving training at a nursing school. ©WHO



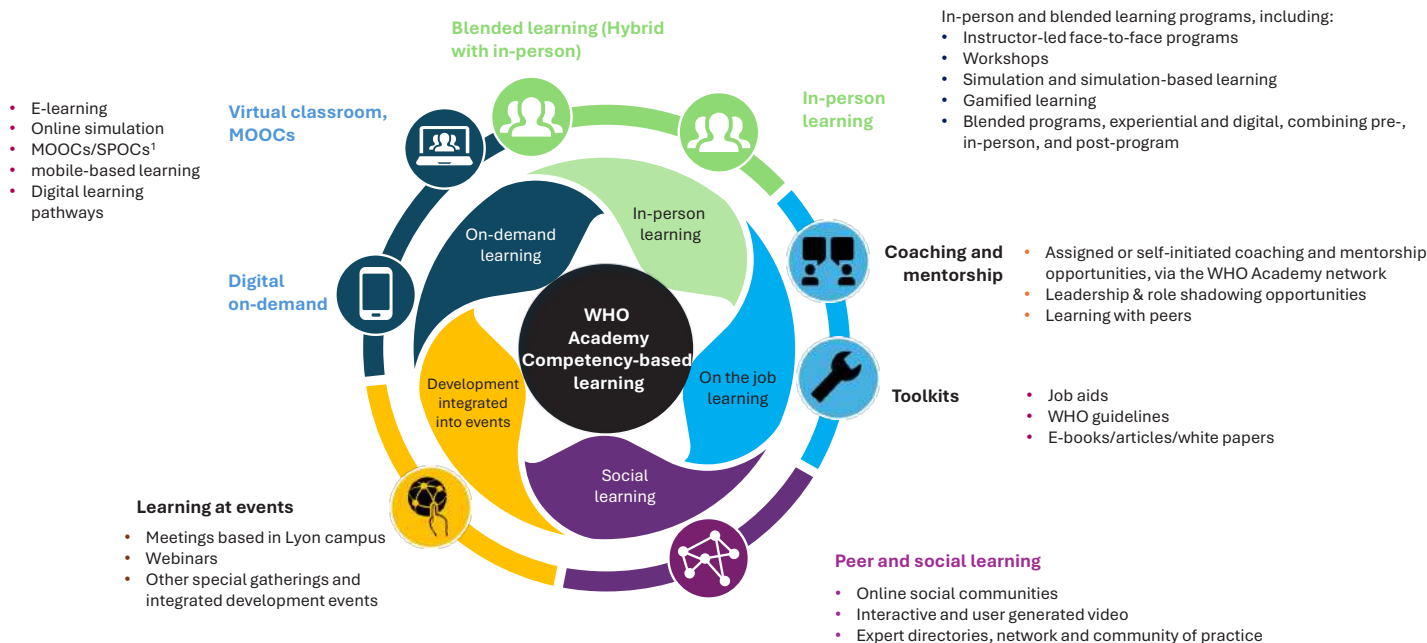
Health professionals from Cameroon participate in a tabletop exercise during the Mass Casualty Management training in Lyon, France. ©WHO/P. Berendes

simulation exercises, serious game learning and knowledge networks.

The Academy collaborates with WHO regional and country offices, and Member States, to identify skill development needs, customize training materials, create tailored learning programmes and deliver training. In each case, the Academy caters to different learning needs and preferences, designing a diverse and inclusive learning environment that enhances the engagement and retention of learners by providing multiple avenues for knowledge acquisition and skill development.

Figure 4

WHO Academy learning delivery model



For example, the *Mass Casualty Management* course helped to enhance the preparedness and response capabilities of healthcare professionals in emergency situations in six countries (Cameroon, Switzerland, France, Belgium, Libya and Ukraine). The five learning sessions reached 117 participants from 25 hospitals, and the course highlight was the simulation exercise held in the WHO Academy simulation centre hosted by the Departmental Fire and Rescue Service in Saint-Priest, close to Lyon, France. Two ‘training of trainers’ sessions with participants from Libya and Ukraine helped ensure the sustainability and scalability of the programme by empowering local trainers to continue the education process.

In addition, *Basic Emergency Care* courses conducted in United Republic of Tanzania and Rwanda have equipped frontline healthcare providers with essential skills to manage acute, life-threatening conditions in resource-limited settings.

The Academy also co-organized workshops and webinars as synchronous learning components of the blended WHO Academy course on *Primary Health Care (PHC) leadership*. Participants came from all six WHO regions and included 116 mid- and senior-level PHC leaders (who were selected from a pool of 2700 applications) from 77 countries. These workshops focused on translating PHC vision into practice, measuring performance for improvement and fostering relationships within health systems to unlock their potential for change.

Additionally, a *Health Taxes* course conducted in Uganda, focused on a multisectoral approach to health prevention, educated policymakers from multiple ministries on the importance of health taxes as a tool for generating revenue for health programmes.



Dr. Louise Joss Bitang, Director of the Yaoundé Emergency Centre, Cameroon. © WHO Cameroon

“The simulation allowed us to apply what we learned in a controlled environment, identifying areas for improvement and building confidence in our response capabilities as there is an urgent need to revise the existing plan and locate resources for the action phase.”

Dr. Louis Joss Bitang
Director of the Yaoundé
Emergency Center, Cameroon

Immersive learning through simulation

In December 2024, at the opening of the WHO Academy, with support from French authorities and the WHO Health Emergencies Programme, 200 participants took part in a simulation exercise in the Academy’s brand-new, state-of-the-art simulation centre in Lyon, France.

Observed by high-level delegates, including President of France H. E. M. Emmanuel Macron and WHO Director-General Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, the simulation learning exercise was developed around a fictional outbreak of a novel zoonotic virus in the city of ‘Globaland’, where the disease spread rapidly through human and animal populations in several countries, triggering a large-scale international public health crisis. The simulation highlighted key components of

emergency response, including the One Health approach, intersectoral coordination and the use of real-time data to inform strategic decisions. Participants moved through dynamic training environments, including a fully immersive hospital setting and an emergency operations centre, experiencing firsthand the intensity and coordination required during such events. It demonstrated the value of simulation-based learning in enhancing healthcare professionals’ skills and competencies and reinforced the need for practical, hands-on training approaches.

Objective 3:

Build a partnership-based global learning ecosystem that promotes innovative lifelong learning practices in the health sector



‘A game-changer’: WHO Academy opening

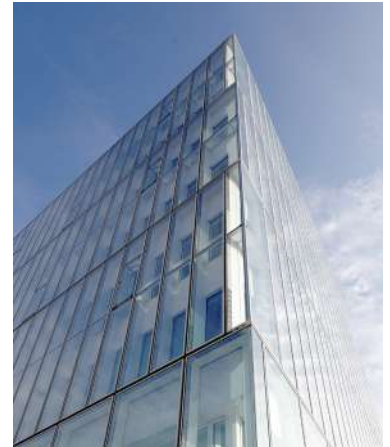
The WHO Academy officially opened its doors on 17 December in Lyon, France, with a high-profile inauguration ceremony. The event was attended by WHO Director-General Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, President of France H.E. M. Emmanuel Macron and numerous health ministers, representatives of UN agencies and international organizations, donors and local French partners.

Over 600 participants attended the inauguration in Lyon, including health professionals, civil society organizations, academic institutions and the private sector, and over 49 000 viewed the livestream online. The event included several welcoming remarks from high-level officials and a live simulation exercise utilizing the building’s state-of-the-art facilities. The event received media coverage from over 40 national and international media outlets and was shared widely on social media.

The Academy’s campus spans 11 000 square meters and includes 22 training rooms, two distance-learning rooms, a simulation centre, an emergency operations centre, a TV recording studio, a modern auditorium and a library. The event also marked the official launch of the WHO Academy online learning platform.

The opening of the WHO Academy was only possible with the support of the Government of France, the Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes Region, the City and Metropole of Lyon, and the private sector donor members of the *Soutien à l’Académie mondiale de la Santé Foundation*, hosted by the *Institut de France*. We thank them for their tireless and unwavering support.

Plaque reveal ceremony of the WHO Academy, in the presence of Grégory Doucet, Mayor of Lyon, Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, WHO Director-General, Emmanuel Macron, President of France, Bruno Bernard, President of the Metropole of Lyon and Catherine Staron, Vice President of the Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes Region (from left to right), on 17 December 2024 at the WHO Academy campus in Lyon, France. Title of WHO staff and officials reflects their respective position at the time the photo was taken. © WHO.



External facade of WHO Academy building
© WHO

“WHO is known for producing world-class technical products – guidelines, norms, and standards – but translating these into real-world action has been hindered by a lack of institutionalized training. Often, our technical products sit unused on shelves or unread in inboxes.”

The WHO Academy will be game-changing, a first-of-its-kind global health learning centre that will equip health and care workers, policy-makers, and our own global workforce with the competencies and skills they need to transform health systems and deliver health for all.”

Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus
WHO Director-General
17 December 2024



Convening global health and learning partners

In May 2024, on the sidelines of the seventy-seventh World Health Assembly, the Group of Friends of the WHO Academy was launched, co-hosted by its five founding members: France, Indonesia, Japan, Qatar and Rwanda. The Group of Friends is dedicated to advancing the WHO Academy in key international forums and advocating for investment in the global health and care workforce. Since May, a further 25 Member States have joined the Group of Friends, as well as two international organizations – the Commonwealth Secretariat and the International Organization of La Francophonie.



Launch of the Group of Friends of the WHO Academy, held on the sidelines of the 77th World Health Assembly. ©WHO/P. Albouy

In March 2024, the board of the *Soutien à l'Académie mondiale de la Santé* Foundation, which was established in support of the Academy and is hosted by the *Institut de France*, agreed in principle to further extend the timeframe of this resource mobilization mechanism. This partnership will be essential to engaging the private sector in investing in the upskilling and training of the global health and care workforce.

The Academy also pursued numerous academic partnerships in 2024, with universities and NGOs in Brazil, Canada, China, France, Germany, Mexico, Singapore, South Africa and the United States of America. These academic collaboration agreements will support lifelong learning in areas such as One Health, antimicrobial resistance, nursing and midwifery, digital health and artificial intelligence, and human rights.

Beyond global engagement, the Academy is also an important actor in the Lyon-Gerland Biodistrict, a dynamic ecosystem where universities, research institutes and biotech industries collaborate on global and local health initiatives. The Academy, as part of the Healthy Cities flagship, is active within the Healthy Cities Network, but also beyond, actively fostering dialogue and knowledge exchange with local actors on a wide range of health issues. This includes an ongoing collaboration with the City of Lyon where the Academy co-organizes training programmes, workshops, seminars and conferences to advance the health learning ecosystem in the city.

Internally, the Academy continued to forge strong collaborative partnerships with regional and country offices, technical divisions and units, and WHO outposted offices. In May 2024, a Collaboration Charter was signed with the WHO Science Division to improve the overall quality of educational and learning materials, ensuring science and evidence are at the centre of joint work, specifically in the development of the Academy's quality standards (see objective 4).



WHO initiative launched in Europe to engage and empower civil society organizations in health emergency responses. ©WHO/Muhssinolmagine

Work with the WHO Hub for Pandemic and Epidemic Intelligence in Berlin, Germany began in 2024 with the signing of our collaboration agreement and the migration of two courses to the Academy's online learning platform. Ongoing work will include the development of four training courses on Public Health Intelligence and Epidemic Intelligence from Open Sources,

with one course created using innovative artificial intelligence methodology. These courses will help public health experts detect, verify, assess and communicate health threats more effectively.

Working with the WHO Africa Regional Office Centre for Excellence in Workforce Development in Nairobi, Kenya, the Academy is jointly mapping capacity building needs for Member States related to pandemic preparedness and response. In the Western Pacific, the Academy developed a plan with the WHO Regional Office to migrate courses from the Pacific Open Learning Health Net platform to the Academy's learning platform. A Collaboration Agreement with the Pan American Health Organization was signed in September 2024 to strengthen links with the Virtual Campus

for Public Health (VCPH), including through the establishment of a gateway portal from the Academy's learning platform to the VCPH. Ongoing work includes aligning and implementing quality standards for training and the localization of learning content for the Region.

WHO Academy regional focal points played an active role in identifying the 16 priority areas for course development for 2024-2025, selecting courses to move into production, and facilitated meetings and events to explore partnership and collaboration opportunities.

WHO staff training health professionals in the use of personal protective equipment. ©WHO/F. Monir



Objective 4:

Develop and
disseminate quality
standards and
a competency-
based recognition
framework



There are currently no widely accepted standards for what constitutes a high-quality health course. But building on WHO's 75 years of expertise in setting global norms and standards, the Academy aims to promote the application of quality assurance standards in the development, implementation and evaluation of the learning materials that are developed in collaboration with WHO technical units.

In 2024, the Academy continued to work closely with the Department for Quality Assurance of Norms and Standards to define Academy quality assurance processes and align them with those in WHO more widely, as well as continue to engage with the International Association for Health Professions Education. As a result, the *WHO Academy Quality Standards and Criteria for Learning Programmes* have been defined under 18 standards and will be published in 2025.

The development of the quality standards has benefitted from expert guidance provided by the WHO Academy Quality Committee, composed of international experts who advise the Academy on quality assurance, standards and best practice in competency-based education in the health sector. Through its working groups, the committee has advanced the Academy's work, including identifying how patient and community engagement can be better embedded in training and courses.

The quality review process has already been instrumental in the design and development of high-quality courses, with more than 150 WHO Academy learning modules (multiple modules can be included in one course) reviewed against the quality standards and criteria.

Pioneering global health learning credentials

The implementation of digital credentials for competency-based education remains a global challenge. The Academy is pioneering the implementation of this approach for lifelong learning in health.

In 2024, a robust approach to digital course credentials was developed and implemented with the WHO Academy Award of Completion, the first type of digital learning recognition, being issued to learners. Benchmarking of the Academy's credentialing framework has commenced to ensure it incorporates best practices in learning recognition.



The Executive Director of the WHO Academy presents a certificate at the conclusion of the Mass Casualty Management training. ©WHO

Objective 5:

Foster a culture of
continuous learning
within WHO



OPENING CEREMONY OF THE WHO ACADEMY

LYON
TUESDAY, 17 DECEMBER
2024



WHO Leadership Excellence Programme

As part of WHO's 'enabling pillar' function, the Academy has a key role in enabling WHO staff to improve and update their professional skills. In collaboration with the Department of Human Resources, the Academy champions effective continuous learning practices throughout WHO.

In 2024, the Academy developed with the Director-General's Office and the Department of Human Resources and Talent Management, the first WHO Leadership Excellence Programme targeting WHO Representatives and Directors from across headquarters and from all six WHO regions. More than 200 learners participated in three online masterclasses from September to November focused on conflict resolution and conducted in three languages (Arabic, English and French).

The online component of the programme was followed by an in-person Leadership Excellence Seminar held in December on the sidelines of the opening of the WHO Academy in Lyon, France. Over 250 participants discussed how to build a high-performance leadership culture, and shared best practices and lessons learned from across the six regions of the Organization.



Dr Rajesh Sambhajirao Pandav, WHO Representative to Nepal.
© WHO

“Health as we all know is multidimensional. To perform my functions effectively in a leadership position, I need to keep learning about social, political, economic and commercial determinants of health as well as to continually improve my core skills in resource mobilization, negotiation and conflict resolution. Working with a diverse multicultural team, I need to be aware of and sensitive to cultural differences to maintain a respectful workplace.”

Dr Rajesh Sambhajirao Pandav
WHO Representative to Nepal

WHO senior leaders from around the world attended the Leadership Excellence Seminar in Lyon, France. © WHO / Brice Blondel



WHO Academy governance and advisory groups

Established in 2024, the WHO Academy Advisory Group on Lifelong Learning in Health includes international experts from each of the six WHO regions and provides the Executive Director and his team with strategic insights that support the positioning of the Academy as an innovative and trusted source for global capacity building and quality training in health.

The group joins the Internal Steering Committee, which was established to advance internal adoption of the Academy within WHO, and the Quality Committee, which finalized the Academy's quality learning standards in 2024. These three entities provide valuable direction and expertise in support of senior leadership decision-making and will continue to provide support as the Academy enters its expansion phase.

Figure 5

WHO Academy governance and advisory groups (as of 31 December 2024)



- **Internal Steering Committee:** Director level WHO staff from headquarters and the regional level that provide guidance and recommendations on strategic issues and advance the adoption of the Academy at the three levels of the Organization.
- **WHO Academy Advisory Group on Lifelong Learning in Health:** Composed of international experts from the lifelong learning and health sectors that provide recommendations on best practice, strategy and innovation at the level of the Executive Director.
- **Quality Committee:** International experts that review and make recommendations on the development of the Academy's quality standards.

Annex 1: Online courses developed by the WHO Academy by priority area

Physical and mental health

Behavioural and mental health

- Caring for children who have experienced violence: Training for health professionals^[1]
- mhGAP: Integrating mental health into primary care^[2]

Infectious, neglected tropical, and non-communicable diseases

- Behavioural counselling
- My 5 moments of hand hygiene

Sexual and reproductive health

- Cervical cancer screening, diagnosis, and management of precancer: VIA
- Cervical cancer screening, diagnosis, and management of precancer: HPV
- Cervical cancer screening, diagnosis, and management of precancer: colposcopy
- Counseling and prescribing of contraception in pharmacies (French, Arabic, Chinese, Russian, Spanish)
- Essential postpartum family planning counselling
- Integration of a human-rights based approach to comprehensive abortion care
- Medical abortion (French, Arabic, Chinese, Russian, Spanish)

Health systems strengthening

Health emergencies and emergency care

- Basic Emergency Care
- Basics of the IHR monitoring and evaluation framework
- Chemical hazards Part I
- Chemical hazards Part II
- Chemical hazards Part III
- Emergency Preparedness and IHR Compliance Simulation
- Introduction to the International Health Regulations (IHR)
- Mass Casualty Management (French, Arabic)
- Strengthening the health sector's role in the sound management of chemicals

Health financing

- Health taxes (French)

Health information systems

- Delivering impact in every country
- Harnessing the power of routine health facility data: HIV
- Harnessing the power of routine health facility data: Malaria
- Harnessing the power of routine health facility data: Tuberculosis (French, Arabic, Chinese, Russian, Spanish)
- Health inequality monitoring

Leadership and governance

- Fundamentals of risk management (French, Arabic, Spanish)

Medical products, vaccines, and technologies

- Regulatory preparedness to authorize the use of pandemic vaccines in importing countries

Primary health care and universal health coverage

- Social participation for universal health coverage
- Strengthening primary health care leadership: Global capacity building course^[3]
- Universal health coverage service planning with WHO's SPDI Platform

Transversal priorities**Climate change**

- Climate change and health

One Health

- One Health: Basics of multisectoral collaboration of the human - animal - environment interface

Population-specific health

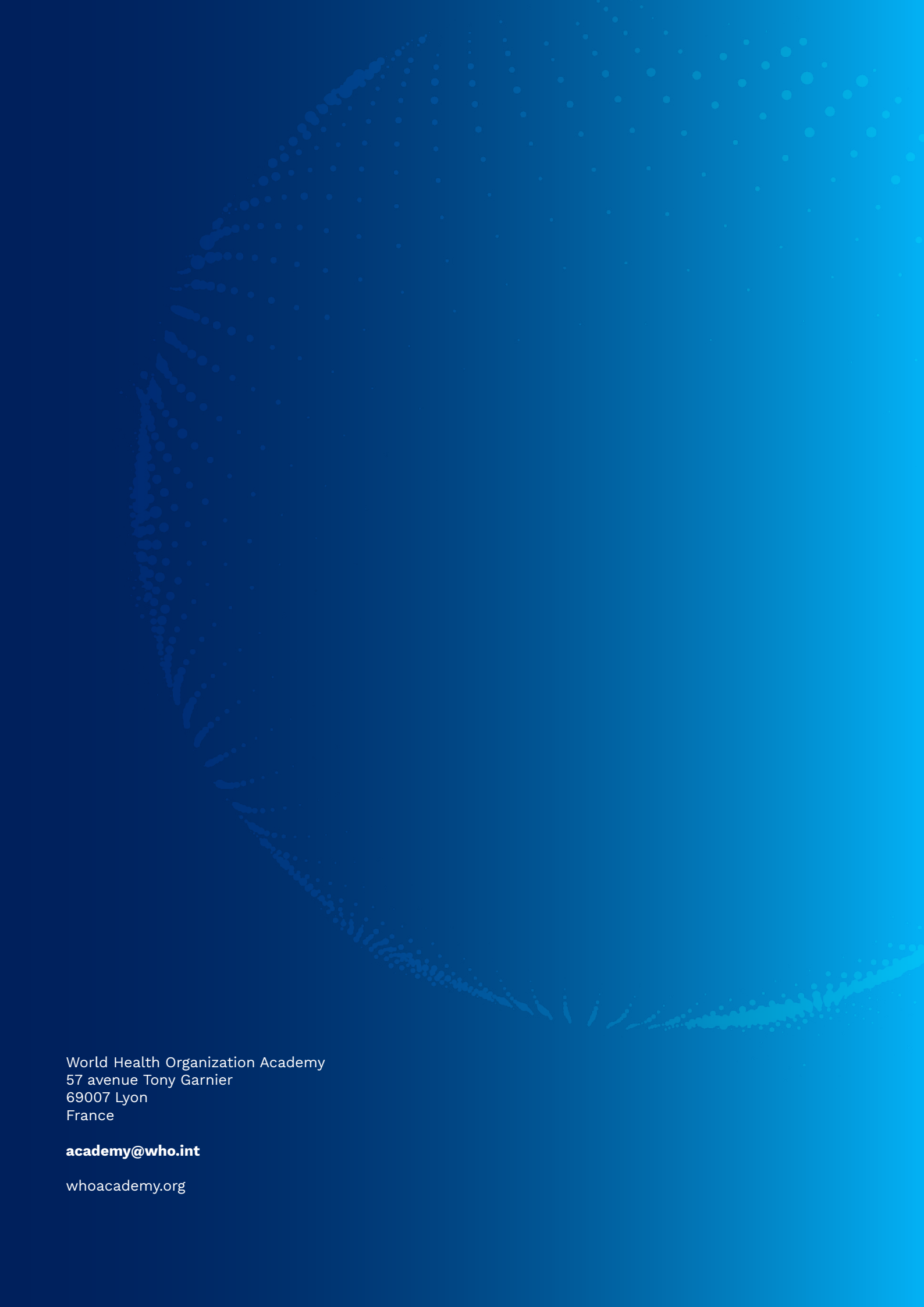
- Integrated management of childhood illness^[4]

^[1] Course also falls under Transversal priorities / Population-specific health

^[2] Course also falls under Health systems strengthening / Primary health care and universal health coverage

^[3] Course also falls under Health systems strengthening / Leadership and governance

^[4] Course also falls under Physical and mental health / Infectious, neglected tropical, and non-communicable diseases



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